Double Q+A BILL

Fatima Sana Shaikh has two big-ticket releases coming up in July



Q. Nobody plans to but you feature in two love stories in July—Anurag Basu's *Metro... In Dino* and *Aap Jaisa Koi*.

I have had back-to-back releases before too. I got to shoot three romances last year so I am glad two of them are coming out. *Mere liye to chaandi hai* [It's a jackpot for me], for they are all such different characters. I play a Bengali in *Aap Jaisa Koi*. I find Bengali women inherently sexy and feminine.

Q. It's a tad ironic that you work with a Bengali filmmaker [Basu] for a Mumbai-set romance while *Aap Jaisa Koi* is set in Kolkata and Jamshedpur and directed by Vivek Soni.

And both of them have presented these cities so beautifully. It was a breeze to work with Maddy [R. Madhavan] in *Aap Jaisa Koi*. He is a fabulous actor, so professional and giving. He is also a filmmaker, so he has a different perspective, which is interesting to observe. And I am a huge fan of Vivek. In the new generation of directors, he is among the rare ones with a strong, special voice.

Q. *Gangster, Life in a... Metro, Barfi!* Basu is the godfather of the romance genre.

I love him and his wife, Tani. There have been times I have called Dada at 2 am and cried about things. When you are friends with somebody, you don't tell them 'give me work', because it doesn't sit right. But, with him, I shamelessly ask for work.

Q. It has been nearly a decade since you started your journey as an actor with *Dangal*. How do you look at your journey so far?

I am very happy and thankful. It is not easy, especially when you have nobody from the industry and are an outsider. I feel very blessed to have got the opportunity to work with such incredible filmmakers and actors. And that I am still working and doing good projects.

—with Suhani Singh